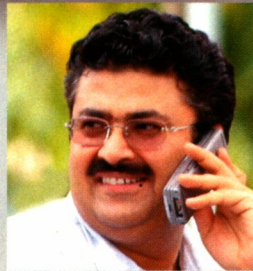


VIJAY SHANKAR PANDEY

For this senior IAS officer, his elevation as Mayawati's principal secretary is just dessert because he had for long been victimised by successive governments. He is seen as Mayawati's hitman and is conducting at least half-a-dozen inquiries, all aimed at turning the heat on SP's Mulayam and Amar Singh in the corruption cases against them.



NAVNEET SEHGAL

Though a new entrant into the inner circle, the tall, suave officer has worked his way up fast and is now seen as Mayawati's image-manager. Networks a lot in Delhi and has a wide array of contacts in almost all states. He also manages her schedules across the country and also accompanies her; his network come in handy for her.



SHAILESH KRISHNA

A workaholic, he is known to reach office at 9 a.m. and seldom leaves before midnight—with his files. This principal secretary's primary task is to take down complaints and grievances from the public and see that these are addressed. Another newcomer to the charmed inner circle, he was brought in at the behest of Shashank S. Singh.



SUDHIR KUMAR GOEL

This Delhi-based old loyalist from Kanshi Ram's days mostly stays away from state politics but provides her with all the crucial inputs that she needs from the capital as Mayawati ups the bar on her ambitions. Played a significant role in making the unconventional Mayawati acceptable among Delhi's chattering classes.



“ Mayawati has fallen for the Left's mirage of making her prime minister. Delhi is a different turf altogether and she must abandon all such hopes. ”

RAJIV PRATAP RUDY

BJP Spokesperson

Fortunately for her, there is now a confluence of her ambition and her allies' desperation. Her ambition is sustained by arithmetic: it was a record of sorts when she won 206 seats in the last Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, that too against such formidable opponents like Samajwadi Party, BJP and Congress, and all of them know that losing the heart of the heartland means only one thing; diminishing national clout. She is a natural born winner, and those who have made a career out of parasitic power quickly acknowledged her market value when politics turned sharply triangular on the eve of the infamous trust vote. Prakash Karat, the apparachik-in-chief, who aspired to be the unofficial arbiter of the Government but humbled by a newly aggressive Manmohan

STANDING TALL: Mayawati has left Kanshi Ram behind in terms of electoral achievements

Singh, was the first to see the revolutionary potential of caste. Banished from the court of Sonia, he took refuge in the shadow of the next powerful woman. It was not that Mayawati was looking for companionship. The comrade was investing in the future. He was not alone. Jostling for space in her durbar were such big daddies of co-habitation politics as H.D. Deve Gowda, a former prime minister, N. Chandrababu Naidu, a proven kingmaker, and Ajit Singh, a Jat leader. When CPI's A.B. Bardhan declared, "Mayawati is fit to be the Prime Minister of India", he was echoing the sentiment of all those leaders who have suddenly discovered encashable virtues in behenji who began her journey from the back alleys of west Delhi.

What is it that makes her irresistible to such disparate leaders? There is hardly anyone like her in Indian politics today. She is the party, the policy; she is the me-alone leader whose power